

The Governor's Choice? Speaker Selection in Nigerian State Assemblies*

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Abstract

Legislatures elect their own presiding officers, yet these officers do not always answer to the chambers that elect them. When does the presiding officer serve the legislative majority, and when the executive? I argue that the effective principal is set by who controls the two resources legislators depend on to hold their seats: entry through candidate nomination, and the fiscal and patronage base that sustains a career. Where the executive controls both and the legislature is weakly institutionalized, the presiding officer becomes an agent of the executive. Using an original dataset covering all 36 Nigerian states across three electoral cycles, 2,975 legislators, I show that Speakers come from the governor's party almost without exception, that governors install junior members over senior co-partisans, and that where the governor's party trails in the chamber the Speaker still follows the governor. The argument generates comparable predictions for other federal democracies in which executives control nomination and intergovernmental transfers.

Keywords: legislative leadership, presiding officers, principal-agent theory, sub-national authoritarianism, state legislatures, Nigeria

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1 Introduction

In January 2025, 36 of 40 members of the Lagos State House of Assembly in Nigeria impeached Speaker Mudashiru Obasa, while he was abroad. Obasa had presided over the chamber since 2015 and was a member of the All Progressives Congress (APC). A Lagos High Court reversed the removal within weeks, and co-partisan President Bola Tinubu, an ally of three decades, intervened to restore Obasa. On the other side of the country in Rivers State, the conflict ran in the opposite direction. Speaker Martin Amaewhule had led 27 of 32 lawmakers across from the People's Democratic Party (PDP) to the APC in December 2023 in alignment with National politics.¹ The Rivers assembly was set on fire on the eve of an impeachment attempt against the sitting Governor Siminalayi Fubara who was still in the PDP. Parallel assemblies convened in separate buildings and federal courts issued contradictory rulings on which body held legitimate authority. President Tinubu declared a state of emergency in March 2025 and the Federal government took over administration of the state. The crisis resolved when Fubara himself switched parties to join the APC in December 2025. By February 2026, eight more sitting governors had switched parties mid-term, and in each case the Speaker either crossed with the governor or the governor had already replaced him with one who would.

Both crises revolved around the same office: the Speaker. The Lagos case shows what happens when the assembly attempts to remove a Speaker whom the governor's federal patron protects. The Rivers case shows what happens when the Speaker answers to a rival principal. Both raise a question of general interest to the study of legislatures. Almost every legislature elects its own presiding officer, and the constitutional text ordinarily makes that officer the servant of the chamber. The presiding officer nonetheless answers to the executive in some settings and to the chamber in others. This paper asks what separates the two. In federal systems the question takes

¹As Section 5.5 sets out, the Speaker remained loyal to the former governor Nyesom Wike, now Minister of the Federal Capital Territory, and the clash between Wike and the sitting governor produced the crisis. Wike serves in the APC national administration but had not formally left the PDP at the time of writing.

a concrete subnational form: when does a governor, rather than the chamber, choose the Speaker?

The answer I propose depends on what legislators rely on to hold their seats. A presiding officer is always an agent, and the effective principal is set by who controls the two resources a legislator needs to hold a seat: entry to the chamber, through candidate nomination, and the fiscal and patronage resources that sustain a political career. Where control over both rests with voters, local parties, and the members themselves, and the legislature has a career structure of its own, the presiding officer answers to the chamber. Where the executive controls nomination and the resource base, and the legislature is weakly institutionalized, the office answers to the executive. The two dependencies define a two-by-two typology, and these two arrangements are its diagonal cells; the institutional conditions place a case in one of the four. I describe the executive-agent cell as a form of internal institutional capture: the presiding office is the point at which a partisan majority becomes executive control of the legislature, the internal counterpart to the executive's capture of the courts and the electoral commissions traced in the subnational authoritarianism literature (Gibson, 2012; Mickey, 2015; Gervasoni, 2010; Giraudy, 2015).

Nigeria is Africa's largest democracy and the most populous federal democracy in the global South. Its 36 states operate under a single federal constitution, so their assemblies share identical formal rules for electing a Speaker, while party control, gubernatorial strength, and the timing of party turnover vary across states and across the three electoral cycles studied here. Qualitative work characterizes Nigeria's state assemblies as "rubber stamps" on the basis of evidence from a small number of states (Baba, 2015, 2019); this paper provides the first systematic test of this proposition across all 36 states.

A Speaker who shares the governor's party is equally consistent with two scenarios: the governor selected the speaker, or the chamber's majority party elevated one of its own, who happens to share the governor's party because the governor's party holds the chamber. The two scenarios differ only where the governor's party and the

chamber majority are not the same. The wave of mid-term governor party-defections between April 2025 and February 2026 provides a set of natural experiments that hold the assembly roster fixed while the governing party changes exogenously, so the Speaker's response identifies gubernatorial control of the chair and separates it from ordinary majority-caucus control. I also exploit the set of state-terms in which the governor's party is not the chamber's largest bloc, together with the governor's choice among co-partisans. If the Speaker were the majority caucus's agent, the office would go to the larger bloc and to senior members.

To test my expectations, I assemble an original dataset of all 108 state-term observations across the 2015–2019, 2019–2023, and 2023–2027 federal electoral cycles, 2,975 legislator-term observations, and 26 documented mid-term Speaker changes. Across every test, the procedurally elected leader of the legislature constitutionally designed to check the governor is in practice the governor's choice. In 28 changes of the governor's party only Rivers produced a Speaker who failed to align with the sitting governor.

This paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 develops the general framework, states the two institutional conditions that locate a presiding office in one of four cells running from chamber agent to executive agent, places a range of federal democracies in those cells, and derives three observable implications for the executive-agent cell that Nigeria occupies. Section 3 describes the institutional setting of Nigeria's state assemblies and the procedural mechanics of Speaker selection. Section 4 describes the data and empirical strategy. Section 5 presents the evidence, including the tests that distinguish executive selection from ordinary majority-caucus control. Section 6 draws out the comparative implications for legislative studies and concludes.

2 Presiding Officers Between the Legislature and the Executive

Federal systems produce subnational regimes that vary in democratic quality even when the national regime is competitive. The Jim Crow South in the US operated as a one-party authoritarian enclave inside a competitive federal democracy for nearly a century (Key, 1949; Mickey, 2015). Argentine provinces under Menem and the Kirchners ranged from competitive to closed, and the closed provinces secured federal transfers that financed continued closure (Gervasoni, 2010, 2018). Mexican states after the Institutional Revolutionary Party's (PRI) national defeat exhibited similar territorial variance; some governors built local hegemonies that outlasted national alternation (Giraudy, 2015; Beer, 2003). Comparative work on India, Brazil, Russia, and post-communist Europe reaches the same conclusion: federal democracies are laboratories of democratic backsliding as much as of democratic experimentation (Behrend and Whitehead, 2016; Giraudy, Moncada and Snyder, 2019; Snyder, 2001; Harbers, Bartman and van Wingerden, 2019; Grumbach, 2022). In the contemporary United States, the nationalization of state politics has turned state governments into vehicles for democratic erosion (Grumbach, 2022).

Two mechanisms recur in this literature. First, subnational incumbents practice boundary control: they prevent national actors and opposition forces from penetrating local arenas (Gibson, 2005, 2012). Second, they capture the authority of state-level institutions, hollowing out the internal operations that would let those institutions check the executive (Mickey, 2015; Giraudy, 2015). State courts, electoral commissions, audit bodies, and security forces lose their procedural independence even where their formal structure remains intact. Both mechanisms so far described operate on institutions that sit outside the legislature. That literature treats the legislature as won at the ballot box; it has not asked how the executive captures the legislature from within after the votes are counted. This paper develops that internal channel. Subnational legislatures in dominant-party settings rarely exercise oversight (Behrend and Whitehead, 2016;

Giraudy, Moncada and Snyder, 2019), and I argue that through the presiding officer, the party majority becomes executive control of the chamber, the internal counterpart to the executive's capture of the courts and the electoral machinery. The literature on presiding officers has developed apart from the subnational work just described, and the rest of this section joins the two.

2.1 When does the presiding officer answer to the executive?

Members choose a presiding officer to run the chamber on someone's behalf, and what those members depend on to keep their seats determines on whose behalf. Two dependencies are important for the principals identity. The first is entry: who controls nomination to the ballot under a viable party label. The second is maintenance: who controls the fiscal and patronage resources a legislator needs to sustain a career once seated. Where both dependencies are on voters, local party organizations, and the members' own district resources, members are the residual claimants on their seats, and the officer they elect answers to them, the chamber majority. Where both depend instead on the executive, members hold their seats at the executive's sufferance, and the officer they elect answers to the executive. A third factor influences how sharply the first two matter: the legislature's own institutionalization, the career structure, seniority norms, and professional staff that give members a stake in the chamber as an institution independent of the executive (Polsby, 1968; Squire, 2007). Weak institutionalization removes that counterweight and lets executive control of entry and resources translate directly into control of the chair.

Table 1 sets out the four scenarios the two dependencies generate and the principal each implies. The diagonal cells are the limiting cases. Where members owe both entry and livelihood to themselves and their voters, the officer is the chamber's agent; where the executive holds both, the officer is the executive's. The off-diagonal cells are intermediate, and they imply a weaker version of each result. An executive who funds legislators but does not choose them can buy votes on particular questions without controlling the chair, because members who can win renomination without

the executive are able to withhold the office. An executive who chooses legislators but does not fund them holds the more durable form of control, since a member who can be denied the ballot has no career to protect, but a chamber whose members command independent resources retains the means to bargain over the terms. Institutionalization conditions all four cells, and weak institutionalization moves a case toward the executive-agent row.

Table 1: Who the presiding officer answers to, by control of entry and of the resource base

<i>Candidate nomination controlled by</i>	<i>Fiscal and patronage base controlled by</i>	
	Members, districts, local organizations	The executive
Members, voters, local party organizations	Chamber agent. The officer answers to the majority caucus; the executive reaches legislation from outside, through the veto. <i>US state legislatures</i> (Clucas, 2001; Mooney, 2013)	Bargained officer. The executive buys votes issue by issue but cannot claim the chair; members who can win renomination without the executive can withhold the office. <i>Brazilian states</i> (Abrucio, 1998; Nunes, 2012)
The executive	Constrained executive agent. The executive names the officer but a chamber with independent resources, or with opposition members in it, bargains over the terms. <i>South African provinces; more competitive Mexican states</i> (Mamogale, 2015; Solt, 2004)	Executive agent. The officer answers to the executive; the chamber ratifies a choice already made. <i>Nigerian states; Argentine provinces</i> (Jones et al., 2002; Ardanaz, Leiras and Tommasi, 2014)

Note: Legislative institutionalization conditions all four cells, with weak institutionalization moving a case down and to the right. Italicised entries are the cases the framework places in each cell, not results. Section 2.2 develops the observable implications used to examine the placement of the Nigerian case, and Section 5 reports them.

Known cases fill all four cells of Table 1. The chamber-agent cell holds United States state legislatures. Candidates win nomination through primaries the governor does not control, they cultivate a personal vote and command district resources of their own, and the chambers have developed professional staff and seniority norms; the Speaker is accordingly the agent of the majority caucus, and the governor reaches legislation through the veto (Clucas, 2001; Cox and McCubbins, 2005; Mooney, 2013; Jewell and Whicker, 1994; Squire and Hamm, 2005; Kousser and Phillips, 2012; Clucas, 2007). A co-partisan governor benefits from the Speaker's agency but does not supply

it.

Nigerian states and Argentine provinces share the executive-agent cell. Section 2.2 treats Nigeria; Argentina is its closest analogue in the existing literature. Provincial party leaders, the governors foremost among them, control renomination, and the resulting legislative careers are short and province-based: only 17 percent of Argentine legislators won re-election between 1983 and 1999, so members invest in the party rather than in the chamber (Jones et al., 2002). Governors also command federal fiscal transfers and the resources of provincial politics, and the least competitive provinces are those where that control runs deepest (Gervasoni, 2010, 2018). Most provinces are accordingly bastions of entrenched elites marked by scarce competition, clientelistic linkages, and a weak division of powers (Ardanaz, Leiras and Tommasi, 2014). The one systematic study of the provincial chambers themselves, covering 23 of them over eighteen years, finds that affiliation with the executive's party structures access to committee and leadership posts (Barnes, 2016). That is the allocation the framework expects when the executive holds both dependencies, and it is the allocation this paper tests for in Nigeria.

Brazilian states occupy the cell in which the executive holds the resource base but not entry. Governors dominate state politics there so thoroughly that the literature calls the arrangement state-level ultrapresidentialism, in which the assembly supplies little by way of a check (Abrucio, 1998). That dominance runs through resources. Open-list proportional representation leaves state deputies with electoral bases of their own, and survey evidence from twelve state assemblies shows governors assembling support by negotiating budget amendments and cabinet appointments, with the effective currency varying by the deputy's constituency and party (Nunes, 2012). Support that must be bought issue by issue is bargained for not commanded, which is what places the Brazilian states in this cell.

The cell in which the executive controls entry but not the resource base holds two cases. South African provinces elect their legislators by closed-list proportional representation, so party leaders control nomination and retention alike, and a member

who defies the party can lose the seat (Maganoe, 2023); provincial legislatures exercise correspondingly limited oversight of provincial executives (Mamogale, 2015). The Mexican states belong here only in part, because they vary: state legislatures institutionalized where multiparty pluralism entered the chamber and stayed subordinate to the governor where it did not (Solt, 2004; Beer, 2003). Mexico therefore spreads across this cell and the executive-agent cell below it, as the framework implies when one dependency varies within a country.

These placements are expectations that can be disconfirmed. A change in either dependency should move a case between the cells of Table 1: a reform that decentralized nomination or gave legislators an independent resource base should shift the office toward the chamber, and centralizing either should shift it toward the executive. The measures developed below for Nigeria, the party of the Speaker, the seniority of the choice among co-partisans, and the response to a change in the executive's party, are the same measures by which the other cases named here could be placed, along with the Indian states, where subnational democratic quality varies widely (Harbers, Bartman and van Wingerden, 2019).

The presiding-officer literature has not tested the prediction outside the United States; the comparative work on Latin American legislatures that addresses presiding officers concerns national chambers, where multiparty coalition bargaining keeps chamber presidents brokering across factions (Morgenstern and Nacif, 2002; Samuels, 2003); and the African literature has likewise concentrated on national assemblies (Barkan, 2009; Opalo, 2019; Fashagba, Ajayi and Nwankwor, 2019; LeVan, Fashagba and McMahon, 2015). Subnational presiding officers remain unstudied. Nigeria's state assemblies are a demanding case for the executive-agent expectation, and the rest of this paper examines it there.

2.2 Nigeria: Executive principal, speaker agent

Nigerian state assemblies are among the most executive-dominated legislatures in the subnational literature (Baba, 2015, 2019; Madueke, 2025), and they meet both of the

framework's conditions. Take entry first. The constitutional rules set out in Section 3 leave the chamber free, in principle, to choose its own presiding officer. In practice the governor controls party nominations and so determines who enters the assembly at all. The pre-vote party caucus, convened on the morning of inauguration, is where he signals his preferred candidate to members of the governing party, and the chamber then elects that candidate. Party switching among sitting legislators is frequent and flows toward the governor's party (Fashagba, 2014; Agboga, 2023), and assembly majorities use impeachment under Section 92(2)(c) as a tool of factional discipline (Muheeb, 2023).

The resource dependency is what places Nigeria in the lower-right cell of Table 1. Nigerian states run on transfers from the federation account, not solely on revenue they raise themselves (Suberu, 2001). In 2023, federation allocations made up 76 percent of the median state's combined allocation and internally generated revenue, and exceeded 70 percent in 27 of the 36 states; only Lagos, at 18 percent, funds itself principally from its own tax base.² Those transfers arrive at the state government, and the governor controls what happens next in both directions. Downward, Section 162(6) of the 1999 Constitution routes local government allocations through a State Joint Local Government Account that the state administers. The Supreme Court held that arrangement unconstitutional in July 2024, yet in the following twelve months governors retained about 4.5 trillion naira of local allocations, roughly a quarter of all revenue distributed across the three tiers (Punch, 2025a); they also control entry to local office, through party primaries and the caretaker committees that substitute for elected councils (Cruz and Johnson-Kanu, 2026). Inward, the assembly's own budget passes through the state Consolidated Revenue Fund, which the governor administers. The Fourth Alteration Act of 2017 amended Section 121(3) to require that assembly funds be paid to the House directly; when the President issued Executive Order 10 in 2020 to enforce it, the 36 states sued and the Supreme Court voided the order in February 2022 (Vanguard, 2022). The state governments went to court to keep the assembly's

²Author's calculation from FAAC monthly reports and NBS internally generated revenue statistics; see Section 4.1. The 2019 and 2022 medians are 76 and 75 percent.

operating budget in the governor's hands, and won.

Nigerian legislators therefore owe both entry and livelihood to the governor, and the assembly is weakly institutionalized, so an executive-agent presiding officer is what the framework predicts. What the governor needs from the chair is a Speaker who will pass the budget, route bills through compliant committees, and block opposition motions, and only a co-partisan can be relied on for all three. The legislative experience and party-loyalty record of candidate Speakers becomes the screening device (Clucas, 2001), and legislators have an incentive to make themselves available as candidate agents, since the office is the most powerful internal position the chamber confers.

H1: Party alignment. Governors should select Speakers from their own party.

Because the governor's party also holds the chamber in most Nigerian states, a co-partisan Speaker is equally consistent with selection by the governor and with ordinary majority-party control of the chair, which is the caucus-agent arrangement of the upper-left cell. The two explanations diverge in two observable places: the state-terms in which the governor's party is not the chamber majority, and the question of which co-partisan receives the office. Section 5 exploits both, and the two implications that follow depend on the second.

A governor selecting from among his own partisans still faces a choice between a Speaker drawn from his own ethnic or geographic base and one drawn from elsewhere in the state. The first maximizes personal loyalty; the second broadens the governing coalition. Governors already command their own base through party structures and patronage, which makes the speakership more useful as an instrument of coalition management than as a reward at home. Legislators can do little to position themselves on this dimension in any case, since ethnic identity is fixed, though party affiliation is not.

H2: Coalition breadth over locality. Governors should not draw Speakers from their own local government area more often than chance would produce.

The third implication concerns what happens when the principal changes. An in-

coming governor of a new party inherits an assembly built by the outgoing party's machinery, and with it a Speaker installed to serve a rival. A presiding officer who answers to the chamber has no reason to go when the governorship changes hands; one who answers to the governor cannot stay.

H3: The party-switch lag. When the governorship changes party, whether at an election or through a mid-term defection, the Speaker should follow.

Where the relationship between the governor and the Speaker breaks down, the Speaker is more likely to be removed from office at the governor's direction. Mid-term Speaker removal therefore offers an additional, indirect signal of the agency relationship under stress. Co-partisanship is a necessary condition for selection by the governor but not a sufficient condition for the agent's survival in office.

3 Speakers in Nigerian State Assemblies

Section 90 of the 1999 Constitution establishes a House of Assembly in each of Nigeria's 36 states, restoring elected state legislatures for the first time since the December 1983 military takeover. Nigeria has had 36 states since 1996 when the last creation of states took place. The 2023 elections were the seventh state-assembly elections cycle of the Fourth Republic, the democratic period that began on 29 May 1999. State assembly elections are held simultaneously across all 36 states on the national electoral calendar (February or March of 2015, 2019, and 2023 for the cycles studied here). Each assembly is unicameral, with between 24 and 40 members elected from single-member constituencies under first-past-the-post (FPTP) rules. Members serve four-year terms and must be at least 30 years of age, sponsored by a registered political party, and educated to at least the School Certificate level (Sections 105–106). Governors are elected separately, in a state-wide single-member contest, under a plurality rule modified by Section 179(2): the winning candidate must hold a plurality of votes statewide and at least one-quarter of votes in at least two-thirds of the state's local government areas. Twenty-nine states hold their gubernatorial elections jointly with the assembly cycle;

seven (Edo, Ondo, Ekiti, Bayelsa, Anambra, Kogi, and Osun) hold them off-cycle as a legacy of court-ordered re-runs that displaced the original timing.

The 991 state-assembly constituencies are population-based and are not coterminous with the 774 local government areas (LGAs). The constituencies in their current configuration predate the Fourth Republic, having been delimited in the 1990s using 1991 census data; despite the 2006 national census, no comprehensive re-delimitation has followed. State assemblies are distinct from local government councils both administratively and territorially. State-level legislation, budget oversight, confirmation of the governor's appointments under Section 192(2), and impeachment of the governor under Section 188 are assigned to the assembly. The Speaker is the presiding officer through whom these state-level powers operate.

Section 92 of the 1999 Constitution establishes the office of Speaker in each State House of Assembly. The Speaker presides over sessions, assigns committees, schedules legislation, and controls floor recognition (Section 93). Section 191 places the Speaker third in the line of gubernatorial succession. The members of the assembly elect the Speaker themselves, by simple majority vote on inauguration day. The vote is therefore formally a legislative choice. In practice, the morning party caucus identifies the governor's preferred candidate and the afternoon plenary installs him, nearly without exception. Contested floor votes for the speakership are rare and themselves signal a breakdown of gubernatorial control over the caucus.

The Deputy Speaker holds the second-ranking position in the chamber. Elected by the assembly on the same inauguration day as the Speaker (Section 92), the Deputy presides in the Speaker's absence, chairs the Committee of the Whole when the chamber resolves itself into committee, and assumes Speaker functions during the speaker's overseas travel or illness. The office matters here for two reasons. It is the second presiding position the governor can populate as part of the same caucus negotiation that produces the Speaker, and pairing rules used in practice typically place the Deputy in a geographic zone of the state distinct from the Speaker's, balancing the chamber leadership across the state's main territorial divisions.

A Speaker can lose office mid-term through four formal mechanisms: impeachment under Section 92(2)(c), which requires a two-thirds resolution for “gross misconduct” but which assembly majorities interpret broadly; court-ordered removal when an election tribunal nullifies the underlying assembly seat; forced resignation under impeachment threat; and death.³

4 Research design

4.1 Data

I assemble original data covering three of the seven state-assembly cycles of Nigeria’s Fourth Republic: 2015–2019, 2019–2023, and 2023–2027. The unit of analysis is the state-term, of which there are 108 ($36 \text{ states} \times 3 \text{ cycles}$). For each state-term I record the Speaker and the Deputy Speaker, with party affiliation and constituency for each, and all 26 mid-term Speaker changes coded by mechanism (impeachment, court order, resignation, or death). I also collect legislator-level records (2,975 in total) covering all 991 constituencies over the three cycles, with name, party, and constituency for each member; these support the conditional logit at the legislator level. Governor records span all 108 state-terms and include name, party, local government area of origin, term status, and election margin where available. State-level controls come from official Nigerian government sources: state population from the National Population Commission (NPC), geopolitical zone, oil-producing status from the Nigerian National Petroleum Corporation (NNPC), internally generated revenue (IGR) from the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS), and federation account allocations from Federation Account Allocation Committee (FAAC) monthly reports.

I collected the legislator-level data through scripted web scraping and PDF extraction from Nigerian electoral sources (the Independent National Electoral Commis-

³Physical exclusion by security forces is qualitatively different from the four mechanisms above: it is extra-procedural, and it appears as an informal tool in mid-term standoffs (the Rivers crisis is the most visible recent example). I treat it as a coercive complement to one of the four formal mechanisms; the 26 mid-term removals recorded in the data all resolve into one of the four formal categories.

sion's (INEC) Declaration of Winners, Stears and eduweb.com.ng election databases, Wikipedia constituency pages, and five Nigerian newspapers), and reconciled Speaker records to the legislator file through a fuzzy name-matching procedure that corrects for inconsistent name renderings in Nigerian press coverage. I verified the 2019 and 2023 legislator records against INEC results; the 2015 records cover all 991 constituencies, with 440 corroborated by two or more independent sources and the remaining 551 drawn from a single source. Full information on sources, the matching algorithm, and verification appears in the online appendix (Section A4). Robustness checks restricting the sample to fully verified records reproduce the substantive findings presented here.

4.2 Empirical Strategy

Selection as Speaker is a binary indicator at the legislator-term level (1 for the Speaker, 0 otherwise). Removal is a binary indicator at the state-term level. Time to removal measures months from the start of the term to the date of removal, censored at 48 months for completed terms. Same party as governor, returning member (a legislator who served in the immediately preceding term, identified through the fuzzy-matching procedure above), gender, and co-locality with governor (the governor's home LGA appearing in the legislator's constituency name) are the legislator-level variables. Co-ethnicity with the governor is not coded as a separate variable for two reasons. First, Nigerian ethnicity is geographically clustered across states and LGAs, so co-locality captures most of the within-state ethnic overlap that the present study can identify. Second, the constituency-level ethnic labels needed to code legislators independently of geography are not systematically available for the 2,975 legislator-term observations. State-term controls include governor's seat share, term status, presidential alignment, geopolitical zone, and state-level economic indicators.

I report descriptive results in the main text. The online appendix reports conditional logit estimates of selection and Cox proportional hazard estimates of removal. The party-switch test exploits the 72 between-term transitions and the nine mid-term governor defections in 2025–2026 as natural experiments to test H3: in each case the

partisan identity of the principal (the governor) changes while the chamber composition remains fixed, so I observe the Speaker outcome as a response to a discrete change in the governor's party.

5 Results

5.1 Profile of Speakers in State Houses of Assembly

Table 2 summarises the 108 Speaker-term observations. The APC accounts for 66 (61 percent) of all speakers, the PDP for 37 (34 percent), and other parties for 5. Twenty-six Speakers (24 percent) did not complete their term. The removal hazard is highest in 2015–2019 (24-month survival 72.2 percent) and lower in subsequent terms (83.3 percent in both 2019–2023 and 2023–2027), as estimated from the Kaplan-Meier curves reported in Section 5.6. Raw removal counts (12, 8, and 6 across the three cycles) reflect both this hazard difference and the censoring window for the still-incomplete 2023–2027 term.

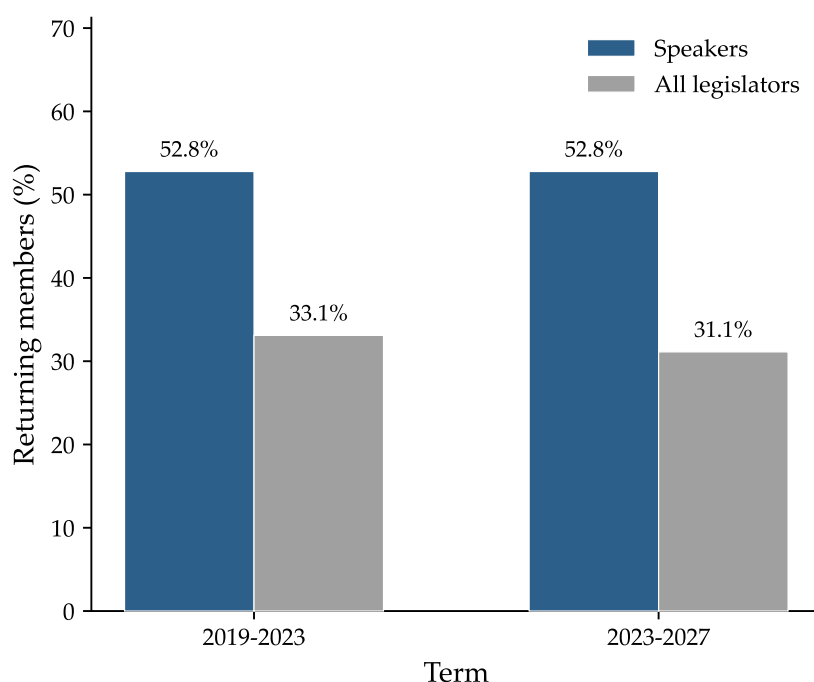
Two women have served as Speaker in the time period studied - Rita Maduagwu (Anambra, 2015–2019) and Jumoke Akindele (Ondo, 2015–2019). Both were impeached. No woman served as Speaker in any state during the 2019–2023 or 2023–2027 terms. Women average 4 percent of all legislators across the three terms; the speakership thus runs below an already low baseline. Mojisola Meranda's brief tenure during Obasa's court-ordered absence in early 2025, subsequently reversed, falls in the same direction.

Table 2: Aggregate Profile of Speakers (N=108). Columns are the three federal electoral cycles over which presidential, gubernatorial, and assembly elections were jointly held.

	2015–2019	2019–2023	2023–2027	Total
<i>Party</i>				
APC	22	21	23	66 (61.1%)
PDP	13	14	10	37 (34.3%)
Other	1	1	3	5 (4.6%)
<i>Gender</i>				
Male	34	36	36	106 (98.1%)
Female	2	0	0	2 (1.9%)
<i>Removed mid-term</i>	12	8	6	26 (24.1%)
Impeachment	8	5	3	16
Court order	2	0	2	4
Resignation	1	2	1	4
Death	1	1	0	2
<i>From governor's party</i>	35	34	32	101 (93.5%)

Speakers were returning members (legislators who had served in the immediately preceding term) in 56 percent of cases in the 2019–2023 assembly and 53 percent in 2023–2027, against base rates of 33 and 32 percent for all legislators in the same terms (Figure 1). The 2015–2019 term is the baseline cycle in the data: it has no preceding term in the panel against which to identify “returning” status, and is therefore not shown in the figure. The Speakers in 2015–2019 are, by construction, all coded as non-returning. Sixteen unique Speakers served across multiple terms; three served in all three (Lawal in Borno, Obasa in Lagos, and Abdullahi in Nasarawa), each in a state where the governor’s party held continuous control across the period.

Figure 1: Returning-member rates for Speakers and for all legislators, by term



Note: A returning member is a legislator who served in the immediately preceding term. The 2015–2019 term has no preceding term in the panel and is omitted.

The online appendix (Table A4) reports the legislator-level conditional logit models of selection (party, experience, gender, and co-locality, with the state-term as the choice set); same-party status and returning-member status both predict selection, while co-locality and gender do not.

5.2 Party Alignment (H1)

Speakers come from the governor’s party in 101 of 108 cases. The alignment rate falls across terms, from 97 percent in 2015–2019 to 89 percent in 2023–2027 (Figure 2). The seven misaligned cases share a common feature: the governorship had recently changed party, and the assembly still reflected the outgoing governor’s party dominance.⁴ The result is consistent with H1.

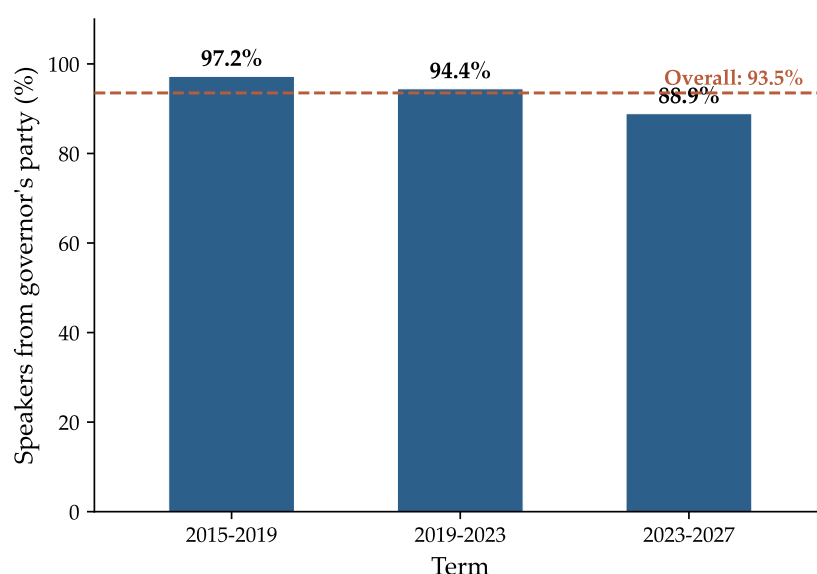
The Deputy Speaker shows the same alignment: 100 of 106 (94.3 percent) of recorded

⁴Misaligned cases (7): Katsina 2015–2019 (PDP Speaker under APC governor); Edo 2020–2024 (APC Speaker under a governor coded mid-term as APC/PDP after Obaseki’s 2020 defection); Edo 2024–2028 (court-contested government change); Osun 2023–2027, Plateau 2023–2027, Sokoto 2019–2023, and Zamfara 2023–2027 (governorship changed party at the most recent election preceding the term).

Deputy Speakers come from the governor’s party, matching the Speaker rate.⁵ Governors place co-partisans in both presiding offices.

Party alignment converts a gubernatorial supermajority into chamber control. In a companion paper covering the same three cycles, the governor’s party held a supermajority (at least two-thirds of seats, the threshold for impeachment) in 30 of 36 assemblies in 2015, 28 of 36 in 2019, and 21 of 36 in 2023 (Johnson-Kanu, 2026). The 94-percent Speaker alignment rate documented here means that in nearly all supermajority states the office controlling the calendar, committee assignments, and floor recognition is also in the governor’s hands. The two facts together account for the absence of a credible Section 188 impeachment threat from any Nigerian state assembly across the period: the votes to remove a governor exist, but the office that would schedule the motion belongs to the governor’s agent.

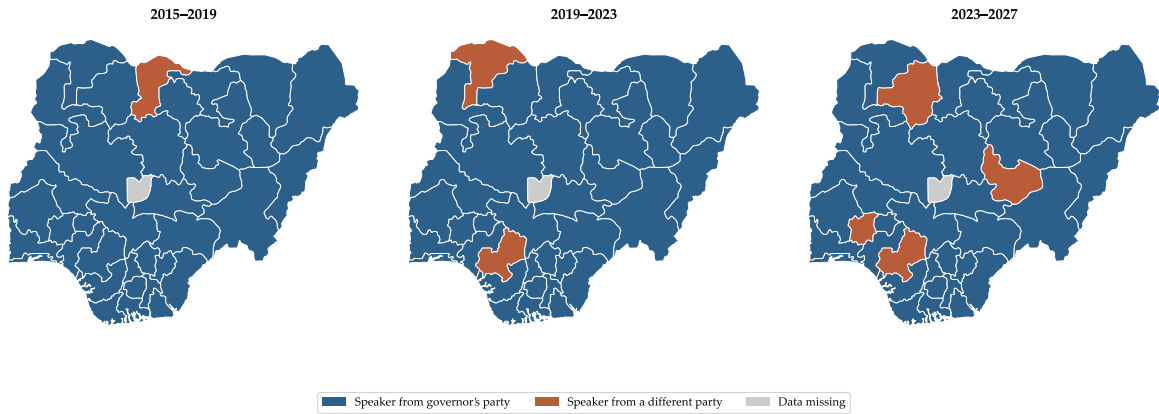
Figure 2: Percentage of Speakers from the governor’s party, by term



Note: Bars cover all 108 state-terms, 36 states across the three electoral cycles. The dashed line is the rate pooled across cycles.

⁵A Deputy Speaker is recorded for all 108 state-terms and a party for 106 of them; the two without a recorded party are Benue and Kogi in 2015–2019. By term the alignment is 32 of 34 in 2015–2019, 34 of 36 in 2019–2023, and 34 of 36 in 2023–2027.

Figure 3: Speaker-governor party alignment by state and term



Note: Each state is shaded by whether the Speaker comes from the governor’s party (blue) or a different party (orange). The seven non-aligned cases concentrate in terms following a recent gubernatorial party change.

5.2.1 Distinguishing Gubernatorial Selection from Majority-Party Emergence

The alignment rate documented above is consistent with two processes that carry opposite theoretical implications. In the first, the governor selects the Speaker from among co-partisans, and the Speaker answers to the governor. In the second, the chamber’s majority party elects one of its own members, who shares the governor’s party only because the governor’s party holds the chamber, and the Speaker answers to the caucus. The second process is the caucus-agent arrangement set out in Section 2. This paper argues for the first: the Speaker is an instrument of internal institutional capture. Wherever the governor’s party is also the chamber majority, the two processes predict the same outcome, a co-partisan Speaker, so the alignment rate cannot separate them, and the governor’s party holds a majority in almost every Nigerian state-term (Johnson-Kanu, 2026). The two processes diverge in two observable places: where the governor’s party is not the chamber majority, and in which co-partisan the office goes to. The tests that follow exploit both implications.

Table 3 reports the first implication. In eleven state-terms the governor’s party was not the chamber’s largest bloc. If the speakership emerged from the majority caucus, the Speaker in these cases would come from the larger opposition party. Dated to the moment of selection, the Speaker came from the governor’s party in eight of

the eleven; the table note dates each case. Plateau in 2015–2019 is the clearest case: the governor’s party held a single seat in a 24-seat chamber, and the Speaker still came from it. A majority-caucus process cannot produce that result. Each of the three exceptions involves court intervention or a subsequent defection; none is a chamber freely elevating its own leader, and two of the three converged to the governor’s party within the term.

Table 3: Speaker selection where the governor’s party is not the chamber’s largest bloc

Term	State	Gov. party	Gov. seats	Largest opp.	Speaker (party)	Follows
2015–2019	Gombe	PDP	5	19	Nasiru Nono (PDP)	governor
2015–2019	Plateau	APC	1	23	Nuhu Ayuba Abok (APC)	governor
2019–2023	Bauchi	PDP	10	20	Abubakar Suleiman (PDP)	governor
2019–2023	Edo	APC/PDP	0	24	Frank Okiye (APC)	governor
2019–2023	Imo	APC	0	13	Chiji Collins (APC)	exception
2019–2023	Sokoto	PDP	14	16	Aminu Manyachida (APC)	exception
2023–2027	Abia	LP	10	11	Emmanuel Emeruwa (LP)	governor
2023–2027	Bayelsa	PDP	11	12	Abraham Igwebere (PDP)	governor
2023–2027	Edo	APC	8	15	Blessing Agbebaku (PDP)	governor
2023–2027	Enugu	PDP	9	15	Uche Ugwu (PDP)	governor
2023–2027	Plateau	PDP	10	13	Moses Sule (APC)	exception

Follows governor at selection: 8 / exceptions: 3

Note: Seat counts and the largest-opposition figure are the end-of-term configuration; a raw party join on those figures returns 7 of 11. The *Follows* column instead dates each case to Speaker selection (assembly inauguration). In both Edo cases the governor (Obaseki) was the Speaker’s party at selection: APC in June 2019, before his June 2020 defection to the PDP (Vanguard, 2020; Premium Times, 2020), and PDP in June 2023, before the APC’s Okpebholo won the November 2024 off-cycle election. Three genuine exceptions remain. In Imo, Speaker Collins (APC) was elected in June 2019 under Governor Ihedioha (PDP); the Supreme Court installed Governor Uzodinma (APC) in January 2020, aligning the governor to the Speaker rather than the reverse (Channels Television, 2020). In Sokoto, Speaker Achida (APC) was elected under Governor Tambuwal (PDP) and defected to the PDP in April 2022 (Channels Television, 2022). In Plateau, Speaker Sule (APC) served under Governor Mutwang (PDP) in a chamber whose APC plurality was produced by Court of Appeal rulings that sacked PDP legislators (The Nation, 2023). Two of the three exceptions converged to gubernatorial alignment within the term.

The second point of divergence concerns the choice among co-partisans. If the Speaker emerged from the internal hierarchy of the majority caucus, the office would tend to go to its more senior members. Table 4 measures the seniority of co-partisan Speakers against the co-partisans available to the governor in the same chamber, where seniority is the number of prior terms served within the period studied.⁶ Across the

⁶The 2015–2019 cohort has no prior cycle in the panel against which to measure seniority and is excluded, leaving 63 co-partisan Speakers across the 2019–2023 and 2023–2027 cohorts. Because the window is truncated at 2015, a Speaker counted as a first-term member may have served before 2015; the truncation applies equally to the Speaker and to the comparison pool, so the relative comparison

two cohorts, 27 of the 63 co-partisan Speakers entered the chamber as first-term legislators, against a first-term rate of roughly two-thirds among all legislators. In the 2023–2027 cohort, where two prior cycles allow seniority to be measured with more resolution, only 16 of 33 Speakers were the most senior available co-partisan, and the governor passed over a more-senior co-partisan in 17 of 33 cases, an average of more than two per chamber. Governors install first-term legislators over established veterans. For example, in Katsina in 2023, seventeen more-senior co-partisans sat in the chamber when a first-term member took the chair. This evidence also speaks against the possibility that governors use the speakership to co-opt potential rivals, since rivals would be the established figures that the office passes over. Governors screen Speakers for dependence, not for standing in the chamber.

Table 4: Is the Speaker the senior figure a majority caucus would elevate?

	2019–2023	2023–2027	Pooled
Co-partisan Speakers tested	30	33	63
First-term Speakers	13 (43%)	14 (42%)	27 (43%)
Speaker is most senior co-partisan	23 (77%)	16 (48%)	39 (62%)
Speaker leapfrogged ≥ 1 more-senior co-partisan	7 (23%)	17 (52%)	24 (38%)
Mean more-senior co-partisans passed over	0.67	2.30	1.52
<i>Memo: first-term rate, all legislators</i>	67%	69%	

These two results fit selection by the governor and not emergence from the majority caucus. They do not contradict the finding that legislative experience predicts selection: Speakers are returning members far more often than the chamber base rate, and the results in appendix confirm the association. Experience screens candidates; it does not entitle the senior one, since governors frequently pass over the single most senior co-partisan and the chamber’s own hierarchy does not determine the outcome.

A caveat worth noting is that pending election petitions add a further consideration to selection that the present data cannot fully adjudicate. A legislator whose seat is under challenge at an election tribunal faces a real probability of mid-term nullification; court order accounts for four of the 26 removals here, and tribunal rulings reshaped

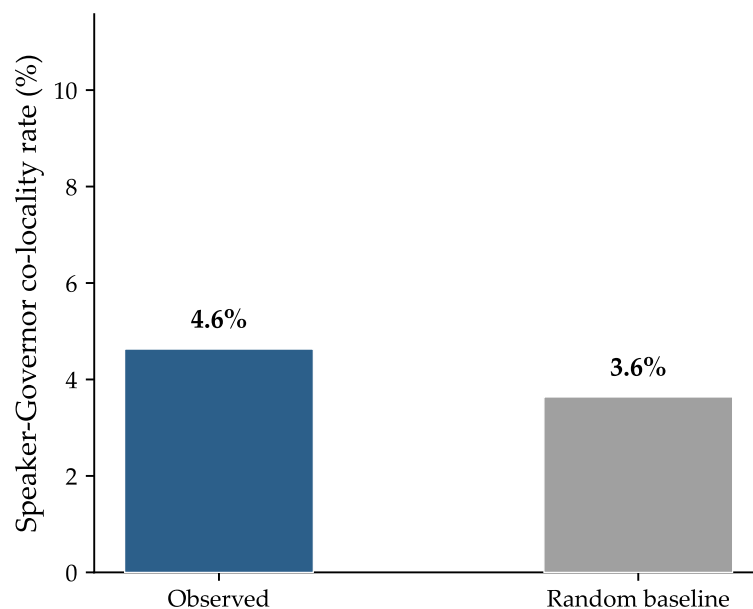
(whether the Speaker is the most senior available co-partisan) is unaffected even though the absolute first-term share is an upper bound.

entire chambers in Imo and Plateau. This cuts in two directions for selection. A governor may avoid placing a Speaker whose seat is insecure, since nullification would force a disruptive succession in the chamber's most important office; alternatively, a governor may use the resources and visibility of the speakership to shield a favored ally, or select an ally because he expects him to prevail at the tribunal. Systematic data on the petition status of each legislator at the moment of selection are not available across the 2,975 legislator-terms, so I leave the direction of this effect to future work.

5.3 Co-locality with the Governor (H2)

Of the 108 Speaker observations, 5 (4.6 percent) share the governor's home local government area. The chance baseline given mean LGA counts per state is approximately 3.7 percent. The two rates are close to identical (Figure 4). Speakers and Deputy Speakers come from different areas in 107 of the 108 state-terms where both constituencies are now identified, the single exception being Taraba in 2015–2019. The result is consistent with H2: governors do not concentrate the speakership in their own locality.

Figure 4: Speaker-governor co-locality rate against the chance baseline

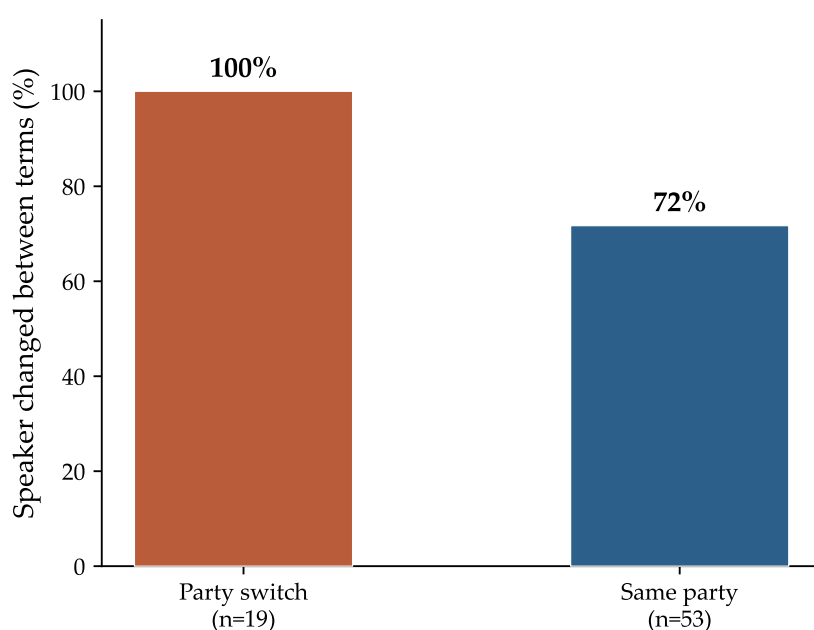


Note: Co-locality is the governor's home local government area appearing in the Speaker's constituency name. The chance baseline is computed from the mean number of local government areas per state.

5.4 The Party-Switch Test (H3)

Of 72 between-term transitions, 19 involved a change in the governor's party. The Speaker changed in all 19.⁷ Among the 53 same-party transitions, the Speaker changed in 35 cases, the great majority involving a new governor of the same party, and survived in 18, mostly under governors who won re-election (Figure 5). This provides evidence that the principal-agent prediction holds.

Figure 5: Speaker replacement rates under gubernatorial party switches and same-party continuity



Note: Covers the 72 between-term transitions across the three electoral cycles, of which 19 involved a change in the governor's party.

Two former Speakers in the data, Sheriff Oborevwori in Delta and Francis Nwifuru in Ebonyi, won gubernatorial elections in 2023.⁸ In both cases the agent who served the principal well went on to the principal's office. Oborevwori and Nwifuru both advanced from same-party speakerships under governors who endorsed their candidacies, so the office also functions as a route to the governorship for Speakers who have served reliably. This bears directly on H3. The office is a credible reward for loyal

⁷Sign test against random direction: $p = (1/2)^{19} \approx 1.9 \times 10^{-6}$.

⁸Oborevwori succeeded the impeached Monday Igbuya in 2017. Nwifuru served as Speaker across 2015–2019 and 2019–2023 in Ebonyi.

service, which strengthens the incentive for sitting Speakers to align with the principal who can promote them.

5.4.1 The Mid-Term Defection Test

Between April 2025 and February 2026, nine sitting governors switched parties mid-term: Sheriff Oborevwori (Delta, April 2025), Umo Eno (Akwa Ibom, June), Peter Mbah (Enugu, October), Douye Diri (Bayelsa, November), Agbu Kefas (Taraba, November), Caleb Mutfwang (Plateau, December), Siminalayi Fubara (Rivers, December), Ahmadu Fintiri (Adamawa, February 2026), and Abba Yusuf (Kano, January 2026) (The Nation, 2025a; Vanguard, 2026). The episodes test H3 under a stricter design. Between-term cases involve an assembly elected at the same time as the new governor; mid-term cases hold the assembly fixed and isolate the Speaker's choice.

In every case, the sitting Speaker ended the episode in the governor's new party.⁹ In seven states the Speaker, already the governor's co-partisan, crossed with him and led the caucus across: Dennis Guwor in Delta, on the plenary floor with 21 other PDP members (Punch, 2025b); Udemé Otong in Akwa Ibom, with 23 of 26 members (The Nation, 2025c); Uche Ugwu in Enugu, who read out the caucus's defection letters before joining the APC himself (ThisDay, 2025); Abraham Ngobere in Bayelsa, with 18 lawmakers (Vanguard, 2025a); John Kizito in Taraba, with 15 others, leaving all 24 members in the APC (The Nation, 2025d); Bathiya Wesley in Adamawa, who led 15 lawmakers across two days before Governor Fintiri's own defection (The Cable, 2026); and Jibrin Falgore in Kano, who endorsed Governor Yusuf's exit from the NNPP and led the caucus to the APC (The Nation, 2025b). The agency relationship survived the change in the principal's affiliation, as H3 predicts.

Two further cases reach the same end-state by different routes. In Plateau, Speaker Gabriel Dewan (PDP, originally Governor Mutfwang's co-partisan) resigned in July 2025 amid party tensions, and the assembly elected Na'anlong Daniel (APC) as the

⁹Sign test against random direction for the nine mid-term cases: $p = (1/2)^9 \approx 0.002$. Combined with the 19 between-term cases above, the joint sign test across 28 independent natural experiments gives $p \approx 3.7 \times 10^{-9}$.

new Speaker (Vanguard, 2025b). Governor Mutfwang himself crossed to the APC five months later, so in Plateau the Speaker changed before the governor did. The Rivers case is the only exception, and Section 5.5 traces it. Speaker Martin Amaewhule followed the former governor Nyesom Wike into the APC in December 2023 while Governor Fubara stayed in the PDP; the two sat on opposite sides of the partisan line for two years, the assembly became Wike's instrument, and the standoff ended only when Fubara himself crossed to the APC in December 2025. Plateau and Rivers reach the same end-state, governor and Speaker in the same party, through Speaker replacement and through governor capitulation respectively. The governor was the one to yield in Rivers, after the institutional cost mounted, which suggests that the office of the Speaker weighs in the governor's calculations against the cost of switching parties.

The timing of these realignments varies with how securely the governor held the office to begin with. Where the sitting Speaker was already the governor's reliable co-partisan, the Speaker moved in step with the governor and led the caucus across the floor, in Adamawa even ahead of the governor's own crossing. Where the Speaker was not the governor's man, alignment came later and by a different route: in Plateau through the Speaker's replacement five months before the governor's own crossing, and in Rivers through two years of open conflict that the governor, not the Speaker, ended by moving. The speed of a Speaker's defection is itself an indication of the prior agency relationship, with the secure cases resolving in days and the insecure ones in months or years.

5.5 Tracing the Mechanism: Rivers and Lagos

The tests in the previous sections establish that the Speaker aligns with the governor and rule out the majority-caucus alternative, but they do not observe the steps that connect the governor to the chair. Two cases, Rivers and Lagos (mentioned in the introduction), allow me to trace that mechanism within each case. The sequence of events goes as follows: The governor controls party nominations and so determines who enters the assembly. On the morning of inauguration the governing-party caucus

signals the governor's preferred candidate. The assembly ratifies that candidate in the afternoon plenary. The installed Speaker then controls the calendar, the committee assignments, and floor recognition. Because the assembly's oversight, budget, and impeachment powers run through the presiding officer, an assembly whose Speaker answers to the governor cannot turn those powers against him. Rivers and Lagos are the two transitions in the data where a link in this chain broke, and each break exposes the link that ordinarily holds.

Rivers is the deviant case that confirms the rule. It is the single transition across the 28 governor party-changes in which the Speaker aligned with a rival principal rather than the sitting governor. Nyesom Wike, the outgoing governor, installed Siminalayi Fubara as his successor in 2023 while retaining the loyalty of most of the assembly, including Speaker Martin Amaewhule. When Wike and Fubara fell out, the misaligned Speaker turned the assembly's own powers against the sitting governor. Amaewhule led 27 of 32 lawmakers from the PDP to the APC in December 2023, following Wike. What followed traces the value of the office directly. The assembly complex was set ablaze on the eve of an impeachment attempt against Fubara in October 2023; a federal court voided the budget Fubara had signed on the ground that no legitimate assembly had passed it; a rival pro-Fubara faction convened as a parallel chamber; and President Tinubu declared a state of emergency in March 2025 that placed the state under federal administration. The standoff ran for two years and resolved only in December 2025, when Fubara himself defected to the APC. The governor, not the Speaker, yielded. The governor capitulated to the Speaker's principal, which is the outcome the agency argument predicts once the chair is lost: recovering it costs the governor his own party affiliation.

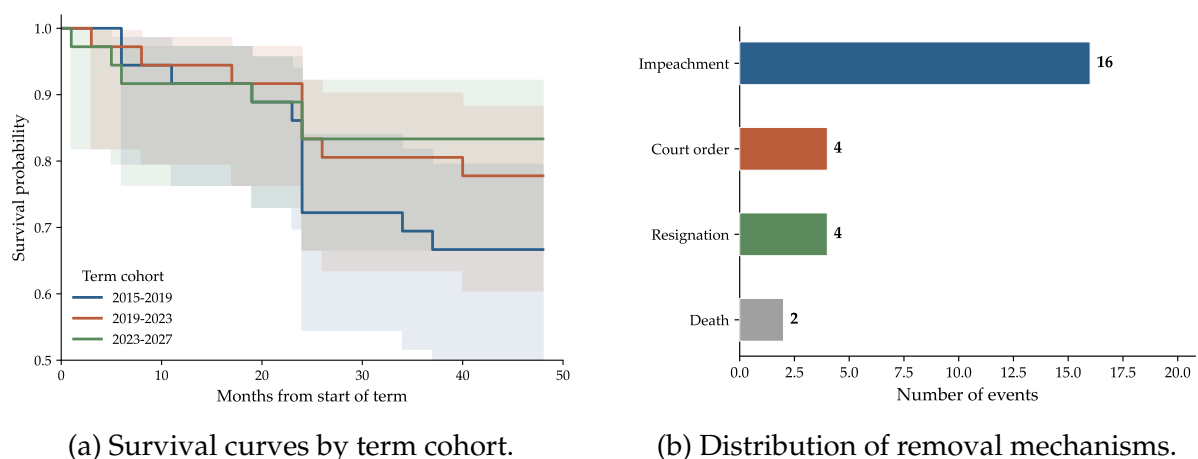
Lagos shows the limits of removing a Speaker after selection, and the role of competing principals. Mudashiru Obasa had held the Lagos speakership since 2015, longer than any predecessor, and had built political capital independent of Governor Babajide Sanwo-Olu. In January 2025, with Obasa abroad, 36 of 40 lawmakers impeached him and installed his deputy. The removal did not hold. A Lagos High Court voided

it in March 2025, and President Tinubu, the APC’s national patron and Obasa’s ally of three decades, intervened to restore him. Two principals had claims on the office, the governor and the national party patron, and when they diverged the higher principal prevailed and the Speaker survived. The Lagos episode shows why the decisive moment is selection at inauguration. Removal afterward is legally uncertain, publicly costly, and draws in external principals who can reverse it. A governor who controls the caucus at the morning inauguration avoids that contest entirely by installing an agent at the outset, which is what happened in the other 27 of the 28 governor party-changes in the data.

5.6 Speaker Removal

Twenty-six Speakers lost office before the end of their term. The four formal mechanisms (impeachment, court order, resignation, and death) account for 16, 4, 4, and 2 cases respectively shown in Figure 6b. Removals occurred in 23 of the 36 states; Plateau, Ekiti, and Edo each saw removals in two of the three terms. Kaplan-Meier survival estimates by term cohort in Figure 6a show a higher removal hazard in 2015–2019 than in subsequent terms, with the curves flattening after the term midpoint.

Figure 6: Speaker tenure and removal dynamics



Note: Panel (a) plots Kaplan-Meier survival estimates by term cohort, with time measured in months from the start of the term and completed terms censored at 48 months. Panel (b) distributes the 26 mid-term removals across the four formal mechanisms.

Logistic regression and Cox proportional hazard models (available in Appendix

Table A6) at the state-term level find no structural predictor of removal. Governor's seat share, term status, presidential alignment, zone, oil status, log population, and log internally generated revenue are each null. Removal in this paper tracks factional disputes that the structural variables in the data do not measure. Speaker removal and attempts at it signal a breakdown in the relationship between the governor and the Speaker, as noted in the introduction.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

This paper tested the argument that the Speaker is the governor's agent. Speakers come from the governor's party at near-uniform rates (101 of 108, 94 percent). They are returning members more than half the time, against base rates of one-third. Same-party status and legislative experience predict selection, co-locality with the governor does not. Where the governor's party is not the chamber majority, the Speaker still comes from it in eight of eleven state-terms, and governors install first-term legislators over more-senior co-partisans, so the alignment reflects the governor's selection, not majority-party control of the chair. When the governorship changes party between terms, the Speaker changes in every case (19 of 19); when the governor defects mid-term, the Speaker either crosses with the governor or has already been replaced by one who will (9 of 9). Mid-term removal correlates with no structural variable recorded in the data and tracks factional dispute that the data cannot measure directly. Across tests, I identify the governor as the principal who selects the Speaker and converts a partisan majority into executive control of the chamber.

These findings extend the subnational authoritarianism literature in two ways. Firstly, capture of internal legislative institutions is the mechanism that converts a partisan majority into executive control. Among the 28 independent natural experiments analyzed in this paper (19 between-term party-switches and 9 mid-term defections), Rivers is the only case where the Speaker did not align with the sitting governor; the cost of that misalignment was high enough that the governor yielded to the Speaker's

principal. The boundary-control framework treats subnational regimes as defended against vertical incursion (Gibson, 2012). This paper adds a horizontal dimension: subnational regimes are also defended against the institutions inside the unit. Speaker selection in Nigerian states is the moment at which a party majority becomes a captured legislature, in the same sense that the appointment of pliant judges and electoral commissioners produces captured courts and electoral bodies in the comparable Argentine and Mexican cases (Gervasoni, 2010; Giraudy, 2015).

Secondly, the co-locality null clarifies what governors are buying with the speakership. In a setting where ethnicity and geography drive much political analysis, governors do not pick Speakers from their own LGA. Governors use the speakership to broaden the governing coalition. Governors already command their own base through party structures and patronage; the Speaker is the position through which they extend that coalition into other parts of the state. The Speaker–Deputy Speaker pairing, which separates the two presiding officers geographically in 107 of the 108 state-terms where both constituencies are identified, reinforces the same logic.

If the speaker’s removal reflected accountability, it would correlate with governance quality. If it reflected the mechanical ease of impeachment under supermajorities, it would correlate with seat share. Neither correlation appears. Speaker removal in this paper instead tracks factional disputes already documented in qualitative work (Muheeb, 2023): rivalries between governors and predecessors, conflicts over the distribution of resources, and intervention by national-level actors. The Lagos case provides a good illustration, a governor’s allies impeached an entrenched Speaker, and a national-level patron reversed the impeachment within weeks.

These results place Nigeria in the executive-agent cell of Table 1, and the placement is informative because the same two dimensions locate other cases in the other cells. Argentine provinces share the cell, since governors there control renomination as well as fiscal transfers (Jones et al., 2002; Ardanaz, Leiras and Tommasi, 2014), and the less competitive Mexican states border it, since legislative institutionalization there tracks pluralism inside the chamber (Solt, 2004; Beer, 2003). Brazilian state assemblies sit in

a different cell: governors there are dominant, but they assemble support by negotiating budget amendments and appointments with deputies who hold electoral bases of their own (Abrucio, 1998; Nunes, 2012). In Nigeria, governor control of nominations, dependence on the federation account, supermajority seat shares, and impeachment as a routine disciplinary tool make the Speaker the governor's agent. What separates the cases is where they fall on the two dimensions.

Two contributions of this paper extend beyond the Nigerian case. The first is internal institutional capture. The subnational authoritarianism literature has traced how governors capture the arenas outside the legislature and defend the unit against vertical incursion; this paper locates a further channel inside the legislature, at the presiding office through which the assembly's own powers operate. Capture of internal legislative leadership, alongside electoral dominance, is how a party majority becomes a captured legislature, and the formal architecture of separation of powers can remain intact while the executive staffs the office that operates those powers. The second modifies the comparative theory of legislative leadership. The dominant theory treats the presiding officer as the agent of the majority caucus, with the executive reaching legislation from outside through the veto. The Nigerian evidence shows that the same office answers to a different principal once the executive controls entry and resources, so the caucus-agent result is a special case of a more general relationship. The comparative-static implication is open to examination elsewhere: presiding officers should shade from chamber agents toward executive agents as executives gain control of candidate nomination and of the fiscal base members depend on, and as legislative institutionalization weakens. The subnational chambers of other federal democracies in which executives control party lists and intergovernmental transfers, among them Mexican states, Argentine provinces, Indian states, and South African provinces, are the obvious settings in which to pursue it. The two tests used here do not require the analyst to observe selection directly, since split-majority chambers and the seniority of the officer relative to the available co-partisans distinguish an executive-agent office from a caucus-agent one wherever the records exist. Reforms targeted at this channel,

secret-ballot speakership elections, minimum tenure protections for presiding officers, and constitutional limits on mid-term impeachment, would create space for legislative independence even within one-party assemblies. Without them, the speakership remains the office through which a gubernatorial supermajority becomes executive control of the chamber.

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